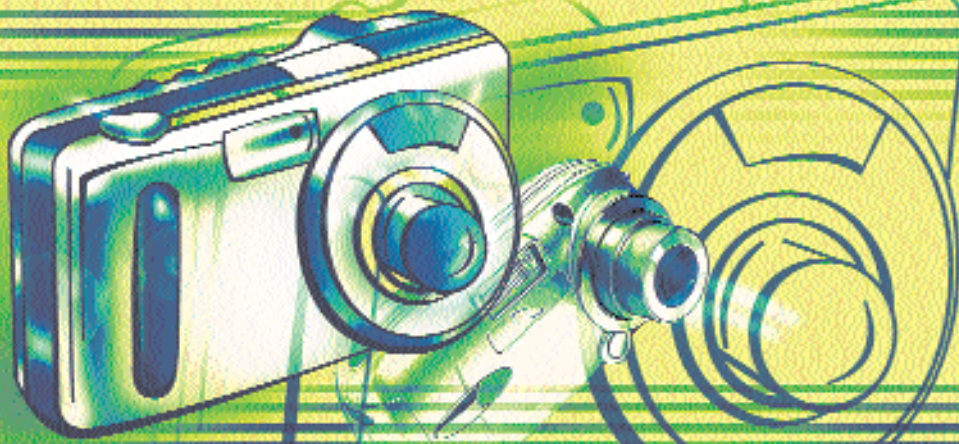




DIGITAL CAMERAS

The digital camera was developed after the invention of the CCD (charge coupled device) which replaces film as the light sensor. A CCD is much more sensitive to light than film is, though it lacks the ability to accurately capture the entire range of the electromagnetic spectrum. Digital cameras give you the convenience of clicking away without worrying about film, and the ability to print directly to a printer is sheer convenience.

It's easy to be overwhelmed by the sheer range of digicams available today, but you need not be. What you really need to do is to thoroughly familiarise yourself with the details common to all digicams, such as optical zoom, megapixel rating, and so on.

Questions to ask the dealer

What is the maximum resolution supported by the camera?

The higher the megapixel rating of the camera, the higher the resolution the camera supports.

How much optical zoom is available?

Optical zoom is especially important outdoors to be able to take close-ups of faraway subjects.

Does the camera support manual mode?

The ability to manually set the exposure and shutter speed means more control

over the quality of the photograph, which you might sometimes need.

What memory card formats does the camera support?

Try and avoid cameras that support proprietary memory card formats. These usually tend to be expensive. They're also usually hard to obtain. Prefer cameras that support popular formats such as SD, MMC, and CF (Compact Flash).

Does it support recording of video?

Video recording capability is fairly common now. Check for this.

Interesting Facts

Prior to 1973, Texas Instruments had designed a filmless but analogue-based electronic camera, but that, of course, cannot be categorised as a digital camera.

In 1973, Steven Sassoon developed the first solid state digital camera. The camera weighed in at eight pounds and had a sensor in the form of a digital cassette tape at 0.01 megapixels. CCDs had only just appeared at that time, and their application in this field hadn't been explored.

Sassoon's digital camera consisted of an analogue-to-digital converter, a movie camera lens, and CCD chips. 1981 saw the launch of the first commercial digital camera.

Usage Tips

❑ Do not expect too much from digital zoom; the photo quality deteriorates when you start using it.

❑ When using zoom, see if you can mount the camera on a tripod, because even mild shakes are amplified when taking a zoomed shot.

Canon
Delighting You Always

❑ Always remember to carry extra batteries with you while travelling.

❑ While photographing with a long exposure time, use a tripod to steady the camera.

❑ Turn off the flash when not required to conserve battery power.

❑ Remember that often, shooting at the highest quality is not necessary, and a lower-quality photo will look just as fine—and it will occupy less space. This, of course, translates to more photographs before you need to do a transfer.

❑ In many cases, you should do fine using the viewfinder instead of the LCD screen for previewing. This will conserve battery charge.

The Future

Film is on its way out, and it has been predicted that by 2008, digital cameras will completely replace film cameras. CCD technology, which is currently used in most consumer digital cameras, is being challenged by CMOS (complementary metal oxide semiconductor) technology. ■

Points To Ponder

Should I consider a high-end camera?

Select a high-end digital camera only if you are very serious about digital photography - an amateur might never use some of the features of such cameras.

Is the weight of the camera important?

If you travel a lot with your camera, you might want to get yourself a light-weight camera. On the other hand, a heavier camera is sturdier to hold and reduces the problem of camera shake.

How much memory should it have?

There should be at least 16 MB of memory to accommodate a decent number of photos. Of course, this depends on the resolution at which the photos are shot.

What about connecting directly to a printer to print photos?

Look for a digital camera that supports standards such as PictBridge—this standard allows you to print photos directly to a compatible photo printer without using a PC.